The Last Deaths

By CK Williams

INTRODUCTION

Turn on the international news any evening and you will see reports of bloodshed – families being slaughtered, children left crying in the rubble of what used to be their home, wondering where mamma and papa have gone. I don't need to name a country – the violence and uprisings are becoming more and more widespread. The Last Deaths by CK Williams examines the situation from the perspective of an American parent. How do we explain our world to our children? The Last Deaths by CK Williams.

1.

A few nights ago I was half-watching the news on
television and half-reading to my daughter.
The book was about a boy who makes a zoo out of junk
he finds in a lot –
I forget exactly; a horse-bottle, a bedspring that's a
snake, things like that –

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And on the news they were showing a film about the
most recent bombings.
There was a woman crying, tearing at her hair and
breasts, shrieking incomprehensibly'
Because her husband and all her children had been killed
the night before
And just when she'd flung herself against the legs of one
of the soldiers watching her,
Jessie looked up and said, "What's the matter with her?
Why's she crying?"

2.

I haven't lived with my daughter for a year now and
sometimes it still hurts not to be with her more.
Not to have her laughter when I want it or to be able to
comfort her when she cries out in her sleep.
I don't see her often enough to be able to know what I
can say to her,
What I can solve for her without introducing more
confusions than there were in the first place.

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That's what happened with death. She was going to step on a bug and when I told her she'd kill it,

It turned out that no one had ever told her about death and now she had to know.

"It's when you don't do anything anymore," I told her. "It's like being asleep."

I didn't say for how long but she's still been obsessed with it since then,

Wanting to know if she's going to die and when and if I am and her mother and grandma and do robbers do it?

Maybe I should have just given her the truth, but I didn't: now what was I going to say about that woman?

"Her house fell down," I said. "Who knocked down her house?" "It just fell."

Then I found something for us to do, but last night, again, first thing,

"Tell me about that girl." "What girl?" "You know," Of course I know.

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What could have gone on in my child's dreams last night so that woman was a girl now?

How many times must they have traded places back and forth in that innocent crib?

"You mean the lady whose house fell down?" "Yeah, who knocked her house down?"

3.

These times. The endless wars. The hatreds. The vengefulness.

Everyone I know getting out of their marriage. Old friends distrustful.

The politicians using us until you can't think about it anymore because you can't tell anymore

Which reality affects which and how do you escape from it without everything battering you back again?

How many times will I lie to Jessie about things that have no meaning for either of us?

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How many forgivenesses will I need from her when all I
wanted was to keep her from suffering the same
ridiculous illusions I have?
There'll be peace soon.
They'll fling it down like sick meat we're supposed to lick
up and be thankful for and then what?

4.

Jessie, it's as though the whole race is sunk in an
atmosphere of blood
and it's been clotting for so many centuries we can
hardly move now.
Someday, you and I will face each other and turn away
and the absence,
The dread, will flame between us like an enormous,
palpable word that wasn't spoken.
Do we only love because we're weak and murderous?
Are we commended to each other to alleviate our terror
of solitude and annihilation and that's all?

5.

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I wish I could change dreams with you, baby. I've had
the bad ones, what comes now is calm and
abstract.
Last night, while you and that poor woman were trading
deaths like horrible toys,
I was dreaming about the universe. The whole universe
was happening in one day, like a blossom,
And during that day people's voices kept going out to it,
crying, "Stop! Stop!"
The universe didn't mid, though. It knew we were only
cursing love again
Because we didn't know how to love, not even for a day,
But our little love days were just seeds it blew out on
parachutes into the summer wind.
Then you and I were there. We shouted "Stop!" too.
We kept wanting the universe to explode,
We kept wishing it would go back into its root, but the
universe understood.
We were its children. It let us cry into its petals, it let
its stems bend against us,

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Then it fed and covered us and we looked up sleepily – it
was time to sleep –
And whatever our lives were, our love, this once, was
enough.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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